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STRATEGIC CHOICES FOR MAJOR POWERS THROUGH THE LENS OF THE ANCIENT CHINESE DISCOURSE ON THE SIX STATES

By Scott Zhijiang Zhang

Introduction

When studying the power structures of modern global multipolar games, policymakers in Washington often tend to rely on Western realist theories. However, to truly gain insight into the underlying behavioral logic of the major powers across the Eurasian continent, one must understand the strategic culture deeply rooted in their civilizational bloodlines. Su Xun (1009–1066 CE), an outstanding strategist of the Northern Song Dynasty, left behind a geopolitical assertion trans-cending a millennium in his classic political essay Discourse on the Six States(六国论)—which analyzed the geopolitical collapse of the late Warring States period (referring to the six ancient Chinese states of Qi, Chu, Yan, Han, Zhao, and Wei, which were successively conquered by the State of Qin between 230 and 221 BCE): "The destruction of the six states was not due to unfavorable weaponry or poor combat, but lay in bribing the Qin." (六国破灭, 非兵不利, 战不善, 弊在赂秦) . That is, the fatal flaw of appeasement through ceding territory to seek peace with Qin.

From an objective geostrategic perspective, the systemic thinking revealed by this political essay is not only a summary of history, but also a striking mirror of the intricate relations among today's seven major powers: the United States, Russia, China, the United Kingdom, France, Germany, and Japan. In this modern version of the "Game of All-Under-Heaven"(天下博弈), the United States, as the core maintainer of the traditional international order, faces the challenge of global defense overextension; Russia and China, as regional major powers with strong projection capabilities, are striving to break through geopolitical containment; while the UK, France, Germany, and Japan are modern "Six States" roles caught in the cracks of a multipolar system, repeatedly oscillating between "concession-based dependency" (让步依附) and "strategic autonomy"(战略自主).

I. The United States: A "Powerful Qin 强秦" at the Core of Order and a Highly Intelligent Strategic Realignment

In the main discourse of Six States, the Qin State is depicted as the single largest underlying dominant force. As Su Xun points out at the very beginning of the essay:

"Apart from capturing territory by force, Qin gained small towns at least and large cities at most. Comparing what Qin obtained through non-military gains to what it won through victorious battles, the former was actually a hundredfold greater; comparing what the feudal states lost through non-military concessions to what they lost through defeat in battle, the former was likewise a hundredfold greater." ("秦以攻取之外，小则获邑，大则得城。较秦之所得，与战胜而得者，其实百倍；诸侯之所亡，与战败而亡者，其实亦百倍".)

From a rational perspective of international relations, the contemporary overall strategy of the United States objectively aligns with this logic of power maintenance. Confronted with realistic challenges such as high domestic public debt, capital hollow-out, and the overload of global geopolitical defense expenditures, strategists in Washington have demonstrated superb systemic operational wisdom: rather than pursuing costly direct military intervention, they execute cost-shifting and capital reshoring "beyond capturing territory by force" ("攻取之外") through rule restructuring, tariff transmission, and the provocation of localized conflicts.

Absorbing Capital for Re-indust -rialization: Through the Inflation Reduction Act and high-priced energy, the U.S. absorbs manufacturing capital from Europe (such as Germany and **France), driving the "re-industriali -zation" of the American mainland.**

Locking in Alliance Dependen -cies: By bolstering security alliances in Asia and expanding NATO eastward in Europe, the U.S. guides its allies to substantially raise their defense budgets and purchase American arms, deeply locking the security and defense systems of Germany and Japan into its own intelligence and technological supply chains. Strategically, this achieves a shrewd layout that prompts allies to fund themselves and shoulder frontline defense on behalf of the central order. This mirrors the ancient Qin State (from its formal founding under Duke Xiang "秦襄公" of Qin in 770 BC to its unification of the six states and establishment of the Qin Dynasty in 221 BC, spanning a 550-year history), which continuously eroded other states through centuries of annexation and ultimately achieved a global realignment of power through highly sophisticated strategic ingenuity.

II. China and Russia: Back-to -Back "Yan-Zhao 燕国-赵国" States and Strategic Resilience Against Hegemonic Contain -ment

When evaluating the resistance of the states of Yan and Zhao, Su Xun assigned them exceptional strategic weight:

"The sovereigns of Yan and Zhao initially possessed farsighted vision; they were able to safeguard their territories, uphold righteousness, and refuse to cede land to appease Qin.

.....It was not until Crown Prince Dan of Yan resorted to dispatching Jing Ke to assassinate the King of Qin as his strategy that calamity was ultimately brought upon the state. Zhao engaged Qin in battle five times, suffering two defeats and securing three victories. Later, when Qin attacked Zhao twice more, both invasions were successively repelled by General Li Mu.". (“燕赵之君, 始有远略, 能守其土, 义不赂秦.....至丹以荆卿为计, 始速祸焉”;“后秦击赵者再, 李牧连却之”)

In a modern context, China and Russia are precisely these modern "Yan and Zhao" powers—stationed at the forefront of defense counterattack, and possessing the robust capability for compre-hensive systemic confrontation.

Russia

(acting as the State of Zhao 赵国 geopolitically; greatly established after the Battle of Jinyang in 453 BC, formally enfeoffed by the King of Zhou in 403 BC, and annexed by Qin in 228 BC—lasting 175 years as a recognized state, or 225 years from its de facto founding): Russia's strategic logic is that NATO's step-by-step eastward expansion has squeezed its traditional security space, creating a desperate predicament where "the more aggressive the encroachment, the more acute the peril."(“侵之愈急”) Russia believes that blind appeasement is akin to what is described in Su Xun’s Discourse on the Six States: "ceding territory to serve Qin brings the greatest of disasters." (“割地事秦, 大患至矣”).

Therefore, it chose to take decisive military action in Ukraine, attempting to completely shatter its geopolitical fate of being gradually encircled and economically locked down throu-gh a tough, high-attrition war (reminiscent of how the famed Zhao general Li Mu repeatedly repelled the Qin forces

at the Battles of Fei 肥之战 and Fanwu 番吾之战).

China

(acting as the State of Yan 燕国 with far-reaching strategy and formally enfeoffed under the Duke of Shao around 1044 BC, and annexed by Qin in 222 BC—lasting approximately 822 years)

China is acutely aware that it faces systemic technological blockades and "de-risking" pressure. China's strategy mirrors Su Xun's description: "possessing a far-reaching strategic vision from the start, capable of defending its territory." (“始有远略, 能守其土”) Rather than blindly engaging in a destructive, head-on collision with the external order, China is building the broadest possible economic and political circle of friends among the Global South by promoting BRICS expansion and jointly building the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). Through "forging widespread friendly bonds and strengthening interdependence" (“广结善缘, 强化依存”), China is attempting to prevent external isolation and containment policies from forming an unbreakable iron wall amid global economic circulation. When facifacing the crisis of national subjugation, Crown Prince Dan of Yan 燕子丹 (?–226 BC) sent Jing Ke 荆轲 to assassinate the King of Qin (?–227 BC); while this "invited disaster all the sooner" (“始速祸焉”), Yan's steadfast resistance gene of refusing to bribe Qin has evolved into a more mature, systemic resilience in modern great power competition.

The current deep strategic collaboration between China and Russia strongly resembles the defensive "Vertical Alliance" (“合纵”) that states were compelled to seek when facing core pressures in the late Warring States period (around the mid-3rd century BC).

IIII. The UK and Japan: "Han and Wei" Following the Core's Footsteps, and the Self-Preservation Dilem-ma Under Deep Binding

In the main body of On the Six States (六国论), Su Xun levels his harshest criticism against the states of Han and Wei: “What did the people of Han and Wei rely on to survive? Zhao once fought five battles against Qin, losing two and winning three. Later, when Qin attacked Zhao twice, both attacks were successfully repelled by Li

Mu. But once Li Mu was executed due to slander, Zhao finally weakened and perished. Therefore, it can be said: The fatal flaw lay in ceding territory to appease Qin." ("韩魏百姓之口, 安得生成？赵尝五战秦, 二败而三胜。后秦击赵者再, 李牧连却之。洎牧以谗诛, 赵卒微亡。故曰:弊在赂秦也。")

Japan

(Geopolitically analogous to Wei; effectively founded in 453 BC, officially recognized by the Zhou King in 403 BC, and destroyed by Qin in 225 BC, enduring for 178 years / 228 years from effective founding).

Situated directly at the intersection of three major geo-political forces—China, Russia, and North Korea—Japan bears extreme, acute geopolitical security anxiety. Japan's strategy is to fully align with the US "Indo-Pacific Strategy," even at the cost of sacrificing its own diplomatic leeway with neighboring countries. It willingly serves as the center order's foremost defensive iron wall in the Asia-Pacific in exchange for security guarantees. This precisely echoes the logic of the State of Wei in the late Warring States period, which repeatedly ceded territory to secure temporary Peace.

The UK

(Politically analogous to Han; effectively founded in 453 BC, officially recognized by the Zhou King in 403 BC, and destroyed by Qin in 230 BC, enduring for 173 years / 223 years from effective founding).

Among the Six States of the Warring States period, Han had the smallest territory and was the first to fall, yet strategically it closely followed Qin's footsteps for self-preservation.Following Brexit, the UK faced adjustments to its international standing and econo-mic leverage.

To maintain its voice as a traditional major power, the UK has strategically become almost a complete shadow of the US on the European continent. Whether taking a tough stance on China or an unyielding posture toward Russia, the UK stays at the absolute forefront. By tightly aligning its diplomatic and mili-tary independence with the dominant ally, it secures a stable ecological niche within the West-ern camp and acts as the van-guard sustaining the Transat-lantic Alliance.

IV. France and Germany: "Qi and Chu" Wavering Between "Strategic Autonomy" and "System Alignment"

As Su Xun 苏洵 points out in the text: "The State of Qi aligned itself with Qin and refused to assist the other five states; once those five states had fallen one after another, Qi inevitably perished along with them.The State of Chu once fought against Qin... but was ultimately defeated, and a catastrophe of immense magnitude descended upon it." ("齐与嬴而不助五国，五国灭，齐亦同灭”;“楚人尝与秦战……后卒辟易，大患至矣”).

France

(Aspiring to the ambitions of the "State of Chu"; formally established around 1042 BC when King Cheng of Zhou enfeoffed Xiong Yi as a viscount, and destroyed by Qin in 223 BC, enduring for roughly 819 years).

France possesses a vast territory and "capable generals," endowing it with formidable potential for confrontation, yet it suffers from internal political fragmentation. France has always maintained a strong pride as an "independent major power," deeply aware that if Europe blindly follows instructions from across the Atlantic, it would be akin to the Six States allowing themselves to be led by the nose by Qin. Continually emphasizing "European strategic autonomy" in its diplomacy, France attempts to play the role of a "third pole" or strategic balancer in the multipolar game (resembling Chu's attempt to unite other forces against Qin).

However, France is constrained by its own economic strength and fiscal limitations, while facing checks and balances within the European Union from pro-US forces like Britain and Poland, making it unable to independently sustain massive European defense autonomy.

Germany

(Trapped in the dilemma of the "State of Qi"; formally established around 1046 BC when King Wu of Zhou enfeoffed Jiang Ziya; the House of Tian succeeded to the state title in 386 BC, and it was finally destroyed by Qin in 221 BC, enduring for roughly 825 years; in the middle and late Warring States period, Qi adopted an isolationist neutral policy of "align

-ing with Qin without assisting the five states," coldly watching the other states perish).

Germany's past strategy bore a striking resemblance to that of Qi—relying heavily on Russia's cheap energy and China's vast market economically, while attempting to remain detached politically and coldly watching the confrontation between major powers (not assisting the five states).

However, with the outbreak of geopolitical conflicts, Germany was forcibly dragged in, compelled to sever its energy ties with Russia and forced into difficult dilemmas regarding supply chains.

Germany's current agony lies in the fact that it is undergoing the hollowing-out pains of its traditional manufacturing sector (such as historical layoffs by automotive giants).

It wishes neither to become a completely dependent Han or Wei, nor does it possess the political confidence of France to pursue "absolute autonomy," ultimately losing its former advantage as an economic leader amid double grievances and severe domestic political friction.

V. Conclusion and Ultim -ate Rehearsal: Three Scenario Predictions

At the conclusion of On the Six States, Su Xun left a deafening warning: "Those who govern a nation must not allow themselves to be intimidated by accumulated might!" (为国者无使为积威之所劫哉!).

In today's era of multipolar transition, the choices of the modern "Six States," the strategic resolve of emerging powers, and the trajectory of America's own transformation are deeply intertwined. Drawing upon the systematic thinking of classical political commentary, we can attempt to make four foundational predictions regarding the evolution of this global order, adhering as closely as possible to the cyclical laws of history:

1st. The Optimistic Predict -ion

The U.S. achieves a highly intelligent "strategic offloading and transformation" alongside an initial multipolar joint governance; Russia and China pursue pragmatic development

without forming a formal strategic alliance; and Britain, France, Germany, and Japan actively shoulder their responsibilities.

This is the most positive deduction based on the famous passage in On the Six States: "If the states of Han, Wei, and Chu had treasured their land; if Qi had not subordinated itself to Qin; if Yan had not sent assassins to assassinate the King of Qin; and if Zhao's brilliant general Li Mu were still alive—then the outcome of victory or defeat, survival or ruin, had these states measured themselves against Qin, might not have been so easy to foretel." (向使三国各爱其地, 齐人勿附秦, 刺客不行, 良将犹在, 则胜负之数, 存亡之理, 当与秦相较, 或未易量).

1.1 The USA Achieves Masterful Strategic Refocus-ing

Confronted with massive domestic debt and global defense expenditures, the United States (the core of the global order) demonstrates extraordinary political wisdom. Instead of single-handedly bearing the heavy burden of the global police officer, it bows to the multipolar trend and proactively initiates a process of "strategic offloading." Through masterful diplomatic finesse, the U.S. successfully transfers primary responsibility for European and Asia-Pacific defense to regional allies with higher stakes. Meanwhile, it retreats to a safer, economically vibrant homeland bounded by two oceans, focusing on high technology and domestic re-industrialization. Resolving its accumulated domestic debt crisis, the U.S. transitions into the most respected and resilient pioneer of innovation in a multipolar world.

1.2 The Two Eurasian Flanks Share the Defense Burden

Following the U.S. strategic realignment, Germany and France come of age. By deeply integrating France’s nuclear deterrent and diplomatic power with Germany’s rearmed conven-tional military capability, they establish a robust "European Independent Defense Force." Operating autonomously within the NATO framework, this force assumes the heavy responsibility of safeguarding Europe, signifi-cantly alleviating Washington

fiscal burden. Concurrently, Japan returns to defensive autonomy, actively enhancing relations with its neighbors through multilateral mechanisms to foster long-term peace in East Asia.

1.3 Russia and China Conso -lidate a Pragmatic Strategic Partnership Without Form -ing an Alliance

Following the establishment of a multipolar balance of power, Russia and China also adjust their strategies. They no longer need to form an extreme anti-U.S. alliance solely for absolute geopolitical security. Once its border security is respected, Russia gradually returns to pragmatic economic and energy dialogues with Europe and the United States. Through economic circulation, China focuses on global market expansion and peacebuilding. Ultimately, under a framework of mutual respect among diverse powers such as the United States, China, Europe, Japan, and Russia, the world achieves a lasting prosperity characterized by "each :appreciat -ing its own beauty, and all coming and all coming together in harmonious order."

2nd. The Pessimistic Pred -iction

Shocks along the China-Russia defensive line trigger systemic overload; Germany, France, and Japan fall into panicked internal friction; and the global order plunges into a systemic collapse.

This is the most pessimistic deduction extrapolated from the argument in On the Six Kingdoms: "The flaw lay in yielding territory to appease Qin, ultimately leading to destruction" ("弊在赂秦，终至颠覆”), as well as the historical outcome that "all six states were eventually eliminated by Qin (“诸侯皆灭”). It describes a volatile ending where a lack of strategic trust among all parties leads to a hard landing for the global system, preventing a smooth transition between the old and new orders.

2.1 The United States Falls into an Imperial Dile -mma of "Unbearable Burd -ens"

Nominally, the United States wins this great power confront

-ation, completely crushing the rise momentum of all potential competitors (drawing an analogy to the six states of Yan, Zhao, Qi, Chu, Han, and Wei in On the Six Kingdoms). However, the cost of this "victory" is heavy. Because the entire Eurasian landmass is reduced to a conflict-ridden ruin and globalization is completely terminated, the U.S. is forced to shoulder an even more massive global stabilization cost that exceeds the limits of its national strength. High overseas military expenditures intertwine with domestic political polarization and a debt avalanche, trapping Washington in a governance trap where it "wins against rivals, yet mortgages its future." Although history formally reverts to unipolarity, global development plunges into long-term stagnation, fragmentation, and depression.

2.2 Geopolitical Imbalance Triggers a Domino Effect

Russia (acting analogously to the state of Zhao in terms of geopolitics), exhausted by protracted and extreme attrition, experiences violent internal political and economic turmoil, causing its Eastern European defense and social systems to fracture into chaos. Meanwhile, China—having lost its geopolitical buffer zones and facing the total "severing" of global supply chains and a tight encirclement of extreme pressures—is similarly forced into a localized security crisis, leading to the complete collapse of the joint stability framework of the non-Western camp.

2.3 Germany, France, and Japan Plunge into the Quagmire of "Latin-Ameri -canization" and Internal Friction

As the Eurasian heartland sinks into protracted geopolitical turmoil, middle powers such as Germany, France, and Japan completely lose their sense of security. Incapable of forging a unified, autonomous force, and cut off from high-value foreign trade markets due to prote -ctionist tariffs and trade barriers, they suffer deeply at home. Driven by soaring defense costs, energy hollowing-out, and a shrinking middle class, Germany, France, and Japan experience fierce clashes among populist forces, leaving tradition

-al establishment politics utterly paralyzed. Consequently, Europe and Japan slide toward the margins of economic stagnation and deteriorating social order a process "Latin-Americanization."

3rd . The Unexpected Ending

The great powers fight to the death, repeating an "Austro -Hungarian-style collapse," while the "outsiders" on the edge of the old order reap the ultimate harvest.

However, the trajectory of history is rarely governed by the will of any single superpower. The strategic choices currently made by the seven major powers—the United States, Russia, China, the United Kingdom, France, Germany, and Japan—are sliding toward a cruel reality that aligns more closely with the cyclical laws of history: alternating between cooperation and confrontation, with enemies and friends shifting in the blink of an eye. Trapped in prolonged, extreme tug-of-wars and localized conflicts, the existing great powers mutually lock and frantically drain one another, ultimately risking dragging the world into a systemic regional war.

This fully fractured stalemate easily calls to mind the collapse of the Austro-Hungarian Empire. Before the outbreak of World War I, Europe’s veteran powers (Britain, France, Germany, Russia, and Austria-Hungary) were similarly bogged down in intricate alliance networks and endless geopolitical friction. Driven by security anxieties, Austria-Hungary declared a hardline war on Serbia to preserve its crumbling imperial prestige, attempting to "curb local vassals" to protect itself. Yet, this death struggle among old powers not only failed to make any single party a winner, but instead detonated an entire chain of causality: the Austro-Hungarian Empire was completely dismembered in the fires of World War I and its map redrawn; Tsarist Russia met its end through internal friction; and the core continental powers such as Britain, France, and Germany were ruthlessly drained of a century's worth of accumulated wealth and vitality.

When today's seven major powers replicate that death struggle on the chessboard of

the Eurasian chessboard-exhaust-ing technology, capital, and geopolitical resources in endless confrontation, the modern "outsiders" on the periphery of the global order watch coldly from the sidelines.

Just like the United States back then, which hovered outside the European meat grinder and ultimately reaped the full dividends, the future variable is overwhelmingly likely to follow the idiom: "When the snipe and the clam grapple, the fisherman profits." (“鹬蚌相争，渔翁得利”). As the reigning superpowers and middle powers mutually overdraw themselves through prolonged confrontation or even collapse structurally from within like the Austro-Hungary Empire, those emerging outsiders—who were originally on the edge of the geopolitical storm, focused on their own development, and spared from having their lifeblood drained by the core of the conflict (whether Turkey, India, or Vietnam, they watch from the sidelines)—will suddenly rise. They will step onto center stage in the posture of sweeping up the ruins, completing the ultimate consolidation of the world's surviving resources to become the new global hegemons that truly unify the realm after the multipolar reshuffling.

Conclusion

For policymakers in today's world, the revelation of history is chilling: the greatness of a major power lies not merely in the sharpness of its weapons, but above all in the clarity of its strategic positioning. How to leap out of the vicious circle of blind confrontation and malignant internal friction, and avoid becoming the next "Austro-Hungarian Empire" in the upcoming geopolitical storm.

These are questions for which ancient Chinese wisdom and modern history offer a clear mirror for posterity.

TRANSLATION

On the Six States
六国论

Author: Su Xun
苏洵
Northern Song Dynasty, 1056 AD
北宋时期 公元1056年

The downfall of the Six States was not due to poor weaponry or ineffective warfare; the fault lay in ceding land to bribe Qin. Bribing Qin sapped their own strength, paving the very path to their destruction.Some may ask: "Did all Six States perish simply because they all bribed Qin?" I answer: The states that did not bribe Qin fell because of those that did. Deprived of strong allies, they could not survive on their own. Thus I say: the fundamental fault lay in bribing Qin.

六国破灭，非兵不利，战不善，弊在赂秦。赂秦而力亏，破灭之道也。或曰：“六国互丧，率赂秦耶？”曰：“不赂者以赂者丧，盖失强援，不能独完，故曰弊在赂秦也。

Apart from what Qin gained through military conquest, the small territories it obtained were numerous towns, and the large ones were entire cities. Comparing what Qin gained through land cessions to what it won through battlefield victories, the former was a hundred times greater. Likewise, comparing the land lost by the feudal lords through appeasement to what they lost in military defeat, it too was a hundred times greater. Therefore, Qin’s ultimate desire and the feudal lords’ greatest threat did not lie in warfare itself. Consider how the ancestors of these lords endured frost and dew, clearing thorns and brambles, just to acquire a few feet or inches of land. Yet their descendants held it in little regard, handing it over to others as if discarding weeds. Today they cede five cities, tomorrow ten, only to gain a single night of peaceful sleep. But when they awake and scan their borders, Qin's troops have arrived once more. Since the land of the feudal lords is finite, while the greed of aggressive Qin is insatiable, the more lavishly they appease it,

the more fiercely it invades. Thus, even without fighting, the outcome between the strong and the weak was already decided. That they ultimately met their downfall was only natural in the course of events. As the ancients said: "Using land to serve Qin is like feeding a fire with firewood—so long as the firewood remains, the fire will not go out." This saying hits the truth directly.

秦以攻取之外，小则获邑，大则得城，较秦之所得，与战胜而得者，其实百倍；诸侯之所亡，与战败而亡者，其实亦百倍。则秦之所大欲，诸侯之所大患，固不在战矣。思厥先祖父，暴霜露，斩荆棘，以有尺寸之地。子孙视之不甚惜，举以予人，如弃草芥。今日割五城，明日割十城，然后得一夕安寝。起 视四境，而秦兵又至矣。然 则诸侯之地有限，暴秦之欲无厌，奉之弥繁，侵之愈急，故不 战而强弱胜负已判矣。至于颠覆，理固宜然。古人云：“以地事秦，犹抱薪救火，薪不尽，火不 灭。”此言得之。

The State of Qi never ceded land to Qin, yet in the end, it followed the other five states into destruction. Why? Because it allied with the House of Ying (Qin) and refused to assist the other five states. Once the five states were destroyed, Qi could not escape its fate either.The rulers of Yan and Zhao initially possessed farsighted vision; they were able to defend their territory and rightfully refused to bribe Qin. Therefore, though Yan was a small state, it was among the last to fall—such was the effectiveness of military defense. It was only when Prince Dan resorted to the plot involving Assassins (Jing Ke) that catastrophe was hastened upon them. Zhao fought Qin in five major battles, suffering two defeats and winning three. Later, when Qin attacked Zhao twice more, General Li Mu repelled them back-to-back. But when Li Mu was executed due to slanderous rumors, the capital of Handan was reduced to a mere province of Qin. It is a tragedy that Zhao used force effectively but failed to persevere to the end.

齐人未尝赂秦，终继五国迁灭，何哉？与嬴而不助五国也。五国既 丧，齐亦不免矣。燕、赵之君，始有远略，能守其土，义不赂秦。是故燕虽小国而后亡，斯用兵之效也。至丹以荆卿为计，始速祸焉。赵尝五战于秦，二败而三胜。后秦击赵者再，李牧连却之。洎牧以谗诛，邯郸为郡；惜其用武而不终也。

When Yan and Zhao stood at the brink of total destruction, their intelligence and strength were isolated and precarious. That they perished upon military defeat was truly unavoidable. Yet, had the three land-ceding states cherished their land, had the people of Qi not aligned themselves with Qin, had the assassin not been sent, and had the brilliant general remained alive, then the odds of victory and the logic of survival might have allowed them to contend against Qin—and the final outcome could not have been easily predicted.

且燕、赵处秦革灭殆尽之际，可谓智力孤危，战败而亡，诚不得已。向使三国各爱其地，齐人勿附于秦，刺客不行，良将犹在，则胜负之数，存亡之理，当与秦相较，或未易量。)

Alas! Had the lands used to bribe Qin been bestowed upon the world's strategists, and had the submissive heart used to serve Qin been spent on treating men of extraordinary talent with courtesy, so that all forces joined together to face west against Qin—I fear the people of Qin would not have been able to swallow a single bite of food in peace! How tragic! Possessing such advantage, yet allowing themselves to be cowed by Qin's long-accumulated power, suffering daily erosion and monthly loss of territory until they rushed headlong into ruin! Those who govern a nation must never allow themselves to be cowed by a rival's accumulated power!

呜呼！以赂秦之地，封天下之谋臣；以事秦之心，礼天下之奇才；并力西向，则吾恐秦人食之不得下咽也。悲夫！有如此之势，而为秦人积威之所劫，日削月割，以趋于亡，为国者无使为积威之所劫哉！

Now, the Six States and Qin were all feudal lords, and while their strength was inferior to Qin's, they still possessed the potential to defeat Qin without resorting to land cessions. If a great empire with the vastness of the whole world were to repeat the tragic precedent of the Six States' downfall—that would be placing itself even below the Six States!

夫六国与秦皆诸侯，其势弱于秦，而犹有可以不赂而胜之之势；苟以天下之大，而从六国破亡之故事，是又在六国下矣！

FROM ROMAN HISTORY TO THE VOICES OF THE SOUL

By Alice Jens

Inter arma enim silent leges —Cicero

Not long ago, during my sharing and discussion on classical music appreciation, I never expected it to spark a series of thoughtful ripples touching upon classical music, ancient Greek philosophy, and famous paintings of Roman history. Leon, the younger brother of my dear Greek friend Nick, reached out to me following this topic. Building upon the conversation, he shared a famous quote by the ancient Roman thinker Cicero:

Inter arma enim silent leges.

Literally translated, it means: In the presence of weapons, laws fall silent. Leon explained, "Since the King's word is the law, the violence represented by the dagger often has a far more decisive effect than such law."

He then asked if I had seen the famous oil painting The Death of Caesar. I replied that, of course, I had, and that I was broadly familiar with the historical episode it portrays.

This world-renowned painting depicts a breathtaking and pivotal moment in the long river of Roman history. On March 15, 44 BC, Julius Caesar, the Dictator for Life of the Roman Republic, was assassinated in the Senate. Fearing that Caesar would completely destroy the republican system and plunge the nation into tyranny, about 60 senators conspired to assassinate him in order to save the republic. With concealed daggers, they inflicted 23 wounds on Caesar, and this once-unconquerable dictator ultimately collapsed on the spot in a pool of blood.

This masterpiece, The Death of Caesar (painted between 1859–1867) by the French Academic master Jean-Léon Gérôme, vividly captures the tragic aftermath of the assassination. Gérôme's brilliance lies precisely in his choice to bypass the dramatic action of the assassination itself: Caesar's cold corpse is abandoned in the foreground, the throne is overturned, and the senators, raising their short swords high, are cheering as they rush into the distant sunlight;

meanwhile, on the empty benches to the right, only a solitary figure remains, watching everything in silence from the shadows. The painter portrays not intense "action," but the silence that follows. Just as Cicero's quote implies: once weapons have spoken, the law falls silent. And in this vast hall, what ultimately remained? This masterpiece is now housed in the Walters Art Museum in Baltimore, USA, acquired by Henry Walters in 1917 and bequeathed to the museum in 1931.

Cicero, who uttered this famous quote, was a great Roman statesman and philosopher contemporary with Caesar. He holds a towering and pivotal position in the history of European civilization. First, he was the master of the Latin language, elevating rigid Latin into a highly mature literary tongue; Renaissance scholars modeled their writing almost entirely after him. Second, he integrated Greek philosophy into Roman thought, proposing the idea of "Natural Law," which posits that justice and reason are universally valid—directly inspiring later concepts of natural human rights and international law. Most importantly, as a "Father of the Fatherland" of Rome, he spent his life fighting against tyrants to defend the freedom of the Republic. He was wary of Caesar's centralization of power, and after Caesar's death, he delivered soaring speeches fiercely denouncing tyranny. Ultimately, he was executed by his political enemies—his hands and head severed—becoming an eternal symbol of resistance against tyranny.

My good friend Nick comes from a Greek family, and his conversation constantly sparks with the effortless wisdom of ancient Greek civilization. I have always held a deep reverence for Greece: figures like Stylianos Kyriakides, the renowned Greek runner at the 1936 Berlin Olympics; the legendary soprano Nana Mouskouri; and the modern musician Yanni have brought such fascinating and stirring highlights to the world. Cicero's view of ancient Greek wisdom as the antidote to Roman order opened up wonderful new avenues in my thoughts.

The ancient Chinese civilization left behind the timeless axioms: "He who attends to virtue finds abundant support, while he who strays from it finds little," and "He who commits many unjust deeds will surely bring about his own ruin." This pursuit of cause, effect, and justice—brimming with Eastern wisdom—shares the exact same spiritual core as the classical philosophy of ancient Greece and Rome.

Human civilizations resonate across time and space upon this spiritual bridge. Mutual respect and communication among different peoples carry a sincerity that cannot be faked.

Therefore, whenever I meet Nick, Leon's brother, we always exchange a firm handshake and look each other straight in the eye—that true sense of mutual understanding and deep affinity leaves everything unspoken yet completely felt.

This also reminds me of my very first landlord when I arrived in New York, USA—a Greek giant nearly two meters tall. He had an extraordinary passion for China and could even sing The East Is Red in clear, authentic Chinese. As it turned out, he had been a sailor on a Greek merchant ship in the 1960s and had visited New China multiple times, leaving a wonderful impression on his younger self.

To this day, I still deeply feel that people who carry the lineage of ancient civilizations always radiate a unique, profound, and positive charisma.

Classical music carries such weight at this moment because, in the ancient wisdom of both China and Greece, music has never been mere entertainment for the ears. In The Republic, Plato is meticulous about musical modes, believing they directly shape the souls of citizens—some modes corrupt virtue, while others foster temperance and courage. In China, the Book of Music (Yue Ji) opens with: "All music arises from the human heart." Music springs from the deepest recesses of the human heart, yet it reaches the "harmony of heaven and earth." Confucius remarked, "To change customs and alter traditions, nothing is better than music." This shares the exact same structural concern as Plato's vigilance regarding musical modes: music is the governance of the soul; whatever you allow it to hear, that is what it will become. Though separated by thousands of miles, both civilizations placed music at the intersection of order and the soul—when laws fall silent in the presence of weapons, music is precisely that which can still speak.
The spirit of classical music does not belong solely to the past. Contemporary composers use the language of orchestral music to respond to historical scenes, allowing this "voice of the soul" to reach everyday people—making it more accessible and easier to resonate with. The work recommended today is a continuation of this spirit in modern times.

Today, I would like to recommend a piece that perfectly combines "Epic Rome" with the "Sacred Soul"—the classic ending theme Now We Are Free from the Hollywood film Gladiator. Composed jointly by score master Hans Zimmer and vocalist Lisa Gerrard, this masterpiece weaves ethereal vocals with a profound sense of history, serving as a perfect hymn that cleanses the soul.

THE RAILS OF HISTORY AND THE SOUL OF THE PRESENT

— On Roman à Clef in Novel and Screenplay Writing and Its Boundaries

By Aewen Shutze

I. Introduction: Roman à Clef as a Chrono-Spatial Suturing Technique

In narratology and dramatic theory, Roman à Clef (a novel or play with a key, commonly translated as "allusive playwriting/fiction") occupies a unique coordinate. Its advanced manifestation in modern film and television creation is by no means a superficial symbolic substitution; rather, it is a deep suturing technique combining psychological mechanisms and historical contexts.

The core charm of this technique lies in precisely projecting the facial features and personality traits of vivid contemporary figures into major historical events that were finalized decades ago. The rails of the story possess historical rigidity, but the passengers in the carriage carry the body temperature, class neurosis, and psychological defense mechanisms of modern people. By pulling back the psychological and aesthetic distance, this creative method allows the audience to abruptly encounter contempora-ry reality in the mirror of history, thereby revealing the isomorphism of human nature across the long river of time.

II. Core Playwriting Techni-ques and Practical Guidel-ines of Allusive Playwriting

To perfectly achieve this cross-temporal personality grafting in a script, screenwriters need to master the following three core techniques. Simultaneously, Syd Field's classic framework can be cleverly borrowed as a technical scaffolding to ensure the dramatic primary motive of character behavior:

1. Personality Distillation and "Essence Stripping"

The behaviors of real-world prototypes usually attach to the contemporary social tools they inhabit. The screenwriter's first step must be to strip away these shells of the era and distill their most core "human code," such as extreme narcissism, pathological fear

of losing control, and demagogic talent that exploits group conformity. During the conception stage, creators should conceal the prototype's name, defining the character purely through their core desires and fatal flaws to complete the character's "de-temporalized" abstraction.

2. Spatiotemporal Translation and "Contextual Suturing"

How can a modern person's psychological mechanism grow reasonably and plausibly within the historical environment of decades ago? This requires borrowing Syd Field's tools of "character biography" and "dramatic need" for spatiotemporal translation. A real person's "modern desires" must be translated into "survival motives" within major historical events. The desire logics of both must be isomorphic, but the tools they rely on to fulfill those desires must be thoroughly historicized. By writing a dual-track character biography, the contemporary psychological trauma of the real prototype is transformed into oppression under a specific system and class environment from decades ago, allowing the personality to grow logical roots against a historical background.

3. "Chamber-Style" Treatment of Historical Events

Since the development of the story must strictly adhere to famous, true historical events from decades ago, screenwriters should adopt a micro-close-up approach—placing characters within the "secondary core circle" of major historical events—to prevent grand historical narratives from swallowing the personality specificity of real prototypes. The general trajectory of major historical events is rigid and irreversible, but the specific details of how history unfolds are elastic and leave room for imagination. Screenwriters plant the masks and personalities of real-world figures precisely in these historical blanks.

III. Classical Textual Pract -ice in Film History: Cross-Temporal Allusion Exemplified by Citizen Kane

In film history and Hollywood creative practice, allusive playwriting is an exceptionally mature weapon. It excels at borrowing grand historical events as a stage to accommodate vivid real-life personalities. The most dazzling textbook coordinate among them is Orson Welles’s Citizen Kane.

In the allusive playwriting model of Citizen Kane, the personality defects of real prototypes intertwine with the historical rigidity of a grand stage. The character Charles Foster Kane showcases an interwoven explosion of dramatic needs, viewpoints, and attitudes amidst historical evolution.

The Rigid Construction of the Historical Stage:

The film precisely shifts its story background to the "yellow journalism" movement and the Spanish-American War—major historical periods of soaring expansion in American journalism decades ago. The story's development strictly follows a series of real, immutable historical rails, such as the rise of old-school American press, the manipulation of modern public opinion, and intervention in imperial expansion.

The Real Personality Suturing of Playwriting:

In the screenplay, the protagonist Kane is endowed with a strikingly vivid personality mask precisely corresponding to contemporary media tycoon William Randolph Hearst. In the cross-temporal translation of dramatic needs, the screenwriter strips away Hearst's specific political and business interests of the time, precisely extracting his "pathological desire for control caused by childhood trauma" and his "extreme starvation for public recognition."

This constitutes the dramatic prime mover that devours everything on screen. In replicating viewpoints and attitudes, the autocratic, black-and-white radical viewpoints and arrogant yet fragile social attitudes Kane displays in the script com -pletely replicate Hearst's spiritual outlook as a monopoly of power in reality.

The script strictly obeys modern American socio-political history, but every time Kane agitates public opinion or buys a newspaper at a historical turning point, he displays the personality masks of modern power figures instantly familiar to contemporary audiences. The audience watches the press history of decades ago, yet scrutinizes the power essence and spiritual emptiness of a Hearst-style media empire right before their eyes. Major historical events become solid bones, while the personality essence of the real prototype becomes the modern soul supporting these historical bones.

IV. Dialectical Confronta -tion Surrounding Roman à Clef: Affirmative vs. Nega -tive Perspectives

Allusive playwriting has always been controversial in terms of artistic expressiveness and dramatic ethics. We need to conduct a profound academic contemplation from both positive and negative dimensions:

Pro Perspective: "Aesthetic Estrange -ment" of Borrowing the Past to Satirize the Present and the Eternal Re-enact -ment of Human Nature.

Constructing Advanced "Aesthetic Distance:

If contemporary real-life figures are depicted directly, audiences often carry strong, preconceived political stances or personal biases to judge them, turning viewing into pure expression of posture. Roman à Clef pushes the stage back by decades, utilizing established historical events as a buffer, allowing the audience to pull back psychological distance. As seen in Citizen Kane, deconstructing the demise of a historical tycoon by drawing back the curtain of time allows contemporary audiences to detach from real-world emotions toward Hearst himself, letting them see the soul dilemmas faced by modern capital giants more objectively and profoundly.

An Antidote to Cure the Malady of "Functional Paper Cutouts" in Traditional Historical Dramas:

Characters in traditional historical or period dramas easily fall into stereotyping and rigidity. Injecting complex, modern, neurotic, selfish, and multifaceted real-life personalities into characters from decades ago often yields miraculous chemical reactions. Drawing on Syd Field's view that "action is character," these characters bearing real-world masks exhibit unpreced -ented class and psychological textures at historical turning points, bringing historical dramas thoroughly to "life."

Revealing the Philosophi -cal Depth That "History Spirals Upward, Human Nature Never Changes":

When audiences discover that a certain figure who died under the wheels of history decades ago shares behavioral logic and masks identical to a certain magnate seen in today's news, a creepy sense of fatalism arises. This proves that human tragedies constantly repeat themselves, vastly elevating the epic framework of the script.

Con Perspective:

"Anachronism" as "Cutting the Feet to Fit the Shoes" and the Suppression of Historical Fatalism

The Deconstruction of Histori -cal Truth by "Anachronism":

People of different eras possess specific spiritual limitations and belief systems. If a screenwriter becomes overly obsessed with the personality masks of real prototypes, forcing a historical figure from decades ago to possess modern thinking, witty dialogue, and psychological defense mechanisms completely transcending that era, the script will be filled with a sense of falseness. For instance,

overemphasizing modern-specific psycholo -gical terminology or cross-era social concepts in a historical drama undermines the sincerity and historical fatalism upon which historical dramas survive.

The Merciless Slaughter of Charact -er "Agency" by Historical Rails:

In Syd Field's screenwriting structure, a character's personality completes its arc through proactive "choices and actions." However, because this technique requires that "story development must follow famous historical events from decades ago," it acts as a heavy historical shackle placed upon the character. If the historical trajectory is too strong (such as the inevitable decline of the Kane empire under the currents of the times and economic laws), the personality specificity of the real prototype is easily swallowed by the rigid historical ending, leading to the collapse of the latter half of the character arc and turning them into a marionette of major historical events.

Degrading into a Narrow "Tool for Venting Personal Grudges" and Artistic Narcissism:

Lacking grand compassion, Roman à Clef easily degenerates into a subtle weapon for screenwriters to launch personal attacks. Simply because they dislike a certain current pubDlic intellectual or capitalist, they hunt down a traitor or profiteer from decades ago to fit their mask. Such creation lacks awe for history and genuine insight into human nature, reducing scripts to petty, "political tabloid-style" satire.

V. Conclusion

An excellent Roman à Clef is never mere historical decoration; rather, it uses real human nature to activate cold history, and uses the grandeur of history to scrutinize the reality of the present. Screenwriters should seek a dynamic balance within this technique: let history provide solid rails, let scientific playwriting theory provide stable wheels, and the force truly driving this train across time and space must be that complex, real human heart capable of resonating across decades.